# THE 16-WEEK BODYWEIGHT TRANSFORMATION

Lose fat. Build muscle. 20-25 minutes, 3-4 days a week.

No gym. No equipment. Just a chair, a counter and a floor.

Beginner program - 4 phases - 15 illustrated exercises - progress tracker

# Welcome

This program is built for a 40-year-old beginner at about 255 lb who wants to lose body fat and add some muscle without a gym. Every session is 20-25 minutes, three to four days a week, over 16 weeks (about 4 months). All movements are low-impact (no jumping), so they are friendly to your joints while still raising your heart rate and building strength.

## How it works

- **Circuit format:** you do each exercise for a set number of seconds, rest briefly, move to the next, and repeat for 3-4 rounds.
- **Four phases** of four weeks. Each phase makes the work a little harder so your body keeps adapting.
- **Quality over speed:** the first goal is clean form. If form breaks down, use the Easier option.
- **Equipment:** a sturdy chair, a sturdy kitchen counter or table, a yoga mat or towel, a timer (phone), and water.

## The 16-week roadmap

| Phase | Weeks | Days / week | Focus | Session |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 Foundation | 1-4 | 3 | Learn form, build habit | ~24 min |
| 2 Build | 5-8 | 3 (+ optional walk) | More range, harder variations | ~24 min |
| 3 Strengthen | 9-12 | 4 | Upper / lower split, muscle building | ~24 min |
| 4 Transform | 13-16 | 4 | Peak intensity, test week | ~24 min |

## Safety first

- Because you are new to exercise and over 40, get a quick check-up from your doctor before starting.
- Stop any exercise that causes sharp pain, dizziness or chest discomfort. Muscle burn and fatigue are normal; joint pain is not.
- Effort scale (RPE): 1 = very easy, 10 = maximum. Work at 5-6 early on and build gradually. You should be able to say a short sentence.
- Take at least one rest day between sessions in Phases 1-2. Sore muscles in the first 2 weeks are normal.

# Every Session: Warm-Up and Cool-Down

## Warm-Up (2-3 minutes)

| Move | Time |
|---|---|
| March in place with arm swings | 45 sec |
| Arm circles (forward and back) | 30 sec |
| Hip circles and gentle torso twists | 30 sec |
| Bodyweight half squats (slow) | 30 sec |
| Cat-cow on hands and knees | 30 sec |

## Cool-Down (2-3 minutes)

| Stretch | Time |
|---|---|
| Standing quad stretch (each leg) | 20 sec |
| Seated or standing hamstring stretch | 30 sec |
| Doorway chest stretch | 30 sec |
| Child's pose | 40 sec |
| Slow deep breaths | 30 sec |

## Fat Loss and Muscle: The Non-Workout 80%

- **Calories:** aim for a modest deficit of about 300-500 calories a day below maintenance. A realistic loss is 1-2 lb per week; you may lose 15-30 lb over 16 weeks.
- **Protein:** about 0.7-1 g per lb of your goal body weight (roughly 140-180 g a day) preserves and builds muscle. Include protein at every meal.
- **Food basics:** mostly whole foods, vegetables at two meals, limit sugary drinks and alcohol, and drink plenty of water.
- **Steps:** build toward 7,000-10,000 steps per day. Walking is the easiest fat-loss tool.
- **Sleep:** 7-9 hours. Poor sleep increases hunger and slows recovery.
- **Track:** weigh yourself 1-2 times a week at the same time, take waist/hip/chest measurements every 4 weeks, and snap photos monthly. The scale will fluctuate; the trend matters.

# Exercise Library

Each illustration shows the start and finish positions. The dark red line is the torso, blue is the working limb, and light blue is the opposite limb.

## **Chair Squat** - Quads, glutes




**How:** Stand in front of a sturdy chair, feet shoulder-width. Push hips back and bend knees until you lightly touch the seat, then press through your heels to stand.

**Cues:** Chest up; knees track over toes; do not collapse onto the chair.

**Easier:** Use a higher seat or hold a counter. **Harder:** Pause 2 seconds on the seat; hover just above it.

## **Bodyweight Squat** - Quads, glutes, core



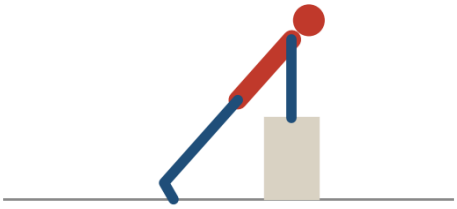

**How:** Feet shoulder-width, toes slightly out. Sit hips back and down until thighs are about parallel, then drive up through your heels.

**Cues:** Weight in heels and mid-foot; chest proud; knees in line with toes.

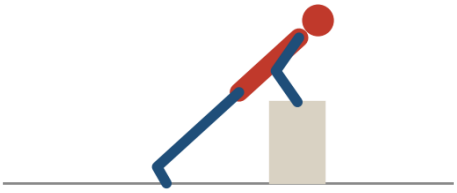
**Easier:** Chair squat. **Harder:** Lower for 3 seconds, pause 1 second at the bottom, then stand.

## **Incline Push-Up** - Chest, shoulders, triceps

Top: arms straight



Bottom: chest to counter



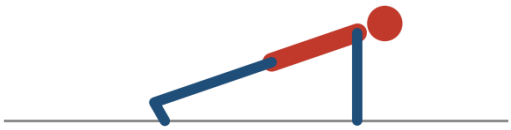
**How:** Hands on a sturdy counter or table slightly wider than shoulders. Body in one straight line. Lower your chest to the edge, then press away.

**Cues:** Squeeze glutes and abs; elbows about 45 degrees from the body.

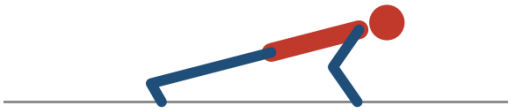
**Easier:** Use a higher surface (wall or counter). **Harder:** Lower surface (stairs, sofa), then floor push-ups.

## **Push-Up** - Chest, shoulders, triceps, core

Top: strong plank



Bottom: chest near floor



**How:** Hands under shoulders on the floor, body straight from head to heels. Lower until your chest is a fist from the floor, then press up.

**Cues:** Do not let hips sag or pike; neck neutral.

**Easier:** Incline push-up, or knees on the floor. **Harder:** 3-second lowering; feet on a low step.

## **Glute Bridge** - Glutes, hamstrings

Start: back flat



Top: squeeze glutes



**How:** Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat hip-width. Drive through heels to lift hips until shoulders, hips and knees line up. Squeeze, then lower.

**Cues:** Ribs down; do not arch the lower back; squeeze at the top.

**Easier:** Smaller range of motion. **Harder:** Hold 2 seconds at the top, or lift one foot (single-leg bridge).

## **Bird Dog** - Core, glutes, back

Start: hands under shoulders

Reach opposite arm and leg



**How:** On hands and knees. Reach one arm forward and the opposite leg back until both are level with your torso. Pause, return, switch sides.

**Cues:** Keep hips square; move slowly; do not twist or arch.

**Easier:** Lift only the leg or only the arm. **Harder:** Pause 3 seconds; touch elbow to knee under you between reps.

## **Dead Bug** - Deep core

Start: arms up, knees over hips

Lower opposite arm and leg



**How:** Lie on your back, arms to the ceiling, knees above hips. Slowly lower the opposite arm and leg toward the floor without letting your lower back lift. Return and switch.

**Cues:** Press lower back gently into the floor; breathe out as you lower.

**Easier:** Lower only the legs (one heel tap). **Harder:** Fully straighten the leg and arm; slow 3-second reps.

## **Plank** - Entire core, shoulders

Knee plank (easier)

Full forearm plank



**How:** On forearms and knees (or toes). Elbows under shoulders, body in a straight line. Squeeze glutes and hold.

**Cues:** Do not let the lower back sag; breathe steadily.

**Easier:** Hands on a counter (incline plank) or knees down. **Harder:** Full plank on toes; lift one foot a few inches.

## **Reverse Lunge** - Quads, glutes, balance




**How:** Stand tall. Step one foot back and lower until both knees are near 90 degrees. Push through the front heel to return. Alternate legs.

**Cues:** Torso upright; front knee over the ankle; light touch of the back knee at most.

**Easier:** Hold a counter or chair for balance; shorter range. **Harder:** Slow 3-second lowering; add a knee-lift at the top.

## **Split Squat** - Quads, glutes




**How:** Take a long staggered stance, feet hip-width apart. Lower the back knee straight down toward the floor, then press up. Finish all reps, then switch legs.

**Cues:** Weight mostly on the front leg; torso tall.

**Easier:** Hold a chair or counter. **Harder:** Elevate the back foot on a couch or step (Bulgarian split squat).

## **Superman** - Lower back, glutes, upper back




**How:** Lie face down, arms extended overhead. Lift arms, chest and legs a few inches, squeeze your back, hold 1-2 seconds, lower.

**Cues:** Look at the floor to keep your neck neutral; small, controlled lift.

**Easier:** Lift only arms or only legs. **Harder:** Hold 3 seconds; add a small flutter.

## **Hip Hinge (Good Morning)** - Hamstrings, glutes, lower back




**How:** Soft knees, hands on hips or across chest. Push hips straight back, torso tilts forward with a flat back until you feel a hamstring stretch, then drive hips forward.

**Cues:** Spine long, hips go back (not a squat); stop before your back rounds.

**Easier:** Smaller range; hands on a counter. **Harder:** Slow 3-second lowering; single-leg hinge with a light toe tap.

## **Mountain Climber** - Core, shoulders, conditioning




**How:** From a high plank (hands under shoulders), drive one knee toward your chest, then switch. Start slow and controlled.

**Cues:** Keep hips level; shoulders stacked over hands.

**Easier:** Hands on a counter or stairs; step feet instead of driving. **Harder:** Faster pace; floor-level hands.

## **Plank Shoulder Tap** - Core, shoulders, stability




**How:** High plank with feet wider than hips. Lift one hand and tap the opposite shoulder, then switch. Resist rotating your hips.

**Cues:** Wider feet = more stable; squeeze glutes.

**Easier:** Do it from your knees or with hands on a counter. **Harder:** Feet closer together; slow taps.

## **High-Knee March** - Heart rate, hips, core




**How:** Stand tall and march in place, driving knees up to hip height while swinging opposite arms. No jumping - this keeps joints happy.

**Cues:** Tall posture; brisk pace; breathe rhythmically.

**Easier:** Lower knee height. **Harder:** Faster pace; add overhead arm reaches.

# Phase 1: Foundation (Weeks 1-4)

Learn the movements, build the habit and tolerance. Slow, clean reps; easy-to-moderate effort (RPE 5-6 of 10).

## Format

| When | Timing | Rounds |
|---|---|---|
| Weeks 1-2 | 30 sec work / 30 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| Weeks 3-4 | 40 sec work / 20 sec rest | 3 rounds |

**Session length:** 3 min warm-up + 18 min circuit + 3 min cool-down = about 24 min

**Schedule:** Mon / Wed / Fri (or any 3 non-consecutive days). Walk 20-30 min on 1-2 other days.

**Progression:** Use the easier option of any exercise you cannot hold form on. Optional: add a 20-minute easy walk on a non-workout day.

### Workout A - Full Body

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Chair Squat | Quads, glutes | Use a higher seat or hold a counter. |
| 2 | Incline Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps | Use a higher surface (wall or counter). |
| 3 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Smaller range of motion. |
| 4 | Bird Dog | Core, glutes, back | Lift only the leg or only the arm. |
| 5 | High-Knee March | Heart rate, hips, core | Lower knee height. |
| 6 | Dead Bug | Deep core | Lower only the legs (one heel tap). |

### Workout B - Full Body

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Hip Hinge (Good Morning) | Hamstrings, glutes, lower back | Smaller range |
| 2 | Incline Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps | Use a higher surface (wall or counter). |
| 3 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Hold a counter or chair for balance |
| 4 | Superman | Lower back, glutes, upper back | Lift only arms or only legs. |
| 5 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Hands on a counter (incline plank) or knees down. |
| 6 | High-Knee March | Heart rate, hips, core | Lower knee height. |

### Workout C - Full Body

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Chair Squat | Quads, glutes | Use a higher seat or hold a counter. |
| 2 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Smaller range of motion. |
| 3 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Hold a counter or chair for balance |
| 4 | Bird Dog | Core, glutes, back | Lift only the leg or only the arm. |
| 5 | Dead Bug | Deep core | Lower only the legs (one heel tap). |
| 6 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Hands on a counter (incline plank) or knees down. |

# Phase 2: Build (Weeks 5-8)

Add range and difficulty. Start feeling muscles work (RPE 6-7). Optional 4th day: 20-25 min brisk walk or Workout A repeated.

## Format

| When | Timing | Rounds |
|---|---|---|
| Weeks 5-6 | 40 sec work / 20 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| Weeks 7-8 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 3 rounds |

**Session length:** 3 min warm-up + 18 min circuit + 3 min cool-down = about 24 min

**Schedule:** Mon / Wed / Fri plus optional Sat brisk walk or repeat of a favorite workout (4 sessions).

**Progression:** Lower the incline for push-ups, move from chair to full bodyweight squats, and move from knee plank to full plank.

### Workout A - Lower + Core

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bodyweight Squat | Quads, glutes, core | Chair squat. |
| 2 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Smaller range of motion. |
| 3 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Hold a counter or chair for balance |
| 4 | Hip Hinge (Good Morning) | Hamstrings, glutes, lower back | Smaller range |
| 5 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Hands on a counter (incline plank) or knees down. |
| 6 | High-Knee March | Heart rate, hips, core | Lower knee height. |

### Workout B - Upper + Core

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Incline Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps | Use a higher surface (wall or counter). |
| 2 | Superman | Lower back, glutes, upper back | Lift only arms or only legs. |
| 3 | Bird Dog | Core, glutes, back | Lift only the leg or only the arm. |
| 4 | Dead Bug | Deep core | Lower only the legs (one heel tap). |
| 5 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Hands on a counter (incline plank) or knees down. |
| 6 | High-Knee March | Heart rate, hips, core | Lower knee height. |

### Workout C - Full Body

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bodyweight Squat | Quads, glutes, core | Chair squat. |
| 2 | Incline Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps | Use a higher surface (wall or counter). |
| 3 | Split Squat | Quads, glutes | Hold a chair or counter. |
| 4 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Smaller range of motion. |
| 5 | Mountain Climber | Core, shoulders, conditioning | Hands on a counter or stairs |
| 6 | Dead Bug | Deep core | Lower only the legs (one heel tap). |

# Phase 3: Strengthen (Weeks 9-12)

Four sessions per week with an upper/lower focus to build muscle and burn more calories (RPE 7-8).

## Format

| When | Timing | Rounds |
|---|---|---|
| Weeks 9-10 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| Weeks 11-12 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 4 rounds, use harder variations |

**Session length:** 2 min warm-up + 20 min circuit + 2 min cool-down = about 24 min

**Schedule:** Mon (A) / Tue (B) / Thu (C) / Sat (D). Never do A and D on back-to-back days.

**Progression:** Slow the lowering phase to 3 seconds on every rep. Move to full push-ups when you can do 12 clean incline reps.

### Workout A - Lower Body

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bodyweight Squat | Quads, glutes, core | Lower for 3 seconds, pause 1 second at the bottom, then stand. |
| 2 | Split Squat | Quads, glutes | Elevate the back foot on a couch or step (Bulgarian split squat). |
| 3 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Hold 2 seconds at the top, or lift one foot (single-leg bridge). |
| 4 | Hip Hinge (Good Morning) | Hamstrings, glutes, lower back | Slow 3-second lowering; single-leg hinge with a light toe tap. |
| 5 | High-Knee March | Heart rate, hips, core | Faster pace; add overhead arm reaches. |

### Workout B - Upper + Core

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps, core | 3-second lowering; feet on a low step. |
| 2 | Superman | Lower back, glutes, upper back | Hold 3 seconds; add a small flutter. |
| 3 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Full plank on toes; lift one foot a few inches. |
| 4 | Plank Shoulder Tap | Core, shoulders, stability | Feet closer together; slow taps. |
| 5 | Dead Bug | Deep core | Fully straighten the leg and arm; slow 3-second reps. |

### Workout C - Full Body Burn

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bodyweight Squat | Quads, glutes, core | Lower for 3 seconds, pause 1 second at the bottom, then stand. |
| 2 | Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps, core | 3-second lowering; feet on a low step. |
| 3 | Mountain Climber | Core, shoulders, conditioning | Faster pace; floor-level hands. |
| 4 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Slow 3-second lowering; add a knee-lift at the top. |
| 5 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Full plank on toes; lift one foot a few inches. |

## Workout D - Lower + Core

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Slow 3-second lowering; add a knee-lift at the top. |
| 2 | Hip Hinge (Good Morning) | Hamstrings, glutes, lower back | Slow 3-second lowering; single-leg hinge with a light toe tap. |
| 3 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Hold 2 seconds at the top, or lift one foot (single-leg bridge). |
| 4 | Bird Dog | Core, glutes, back | Pause 3 seconds; touch elbow to knee under you between reps. |
| 5 | Mountain Climber | Core, shoulders, conditioning | Faster pace; floor-level hands. |

Use the Harder column as your goal for each exercise once the standard version feels comfortable.

# Phase 4: Transform (Weeks 13-16)

Peak intensity. Use your harder variations and tempo to keep progressing (RPE 8). Week 16 is a test week.

## Format

| When | Timing | Rounds |
|---|---|---|
| Weeks 13-14 | 50 sec work / 10 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| Weeks 15-16 | 50 sec work / 10 sec rest | 4 rounds, hardest variation you can do with clean form |

**Session length:** 2 min warm-up + 20 min circuit + 2 min cool-down = about 24 min

**Schedule:** Mon (A) / Tue (B) / Thu (C) / Sat (D).

**Progression:** Test week (16): max clean push-ups, chair-free squats in 60 seconds, plank hold time. Compare with Week 1.

### Workout A - Lower Body

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bodyweight Squat | Quads, glutes, core | Lower for 3 seconds, pause 1 second at the bottom, then stand. |
| 2 | Split Squat | Quads, glutes | Elevate the back foot on a couch or step (Bulgarian split squat). |
| 3 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Hold 2 seconds at the top, or lift one foot (single-leg bridge). |
| 4 | Hip Hinge (Good Morning) | Hamstrings, glutes, lower back | Slow 3-second lowering; single-leg hinge with a light toe tap. |
| 5 | High-Knee March | Heart rate, hips, core | Faster pace; add overhead arm reaches. |

### Workout B - Upper + Core

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps, core | 3-second lowering; feet on a low step. |
| 2 | Superman | Lower back, glutes, upper back | Hold 3 seconds; add a small flutter. |
| 3 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Full plank on toes; lift one foot a few inches. |
| 4 | Plank Shoulder Tap | Core, shoulders, stability | Feet closer together; slow taps. |
| 5 | Dead Bug | Deep core | Fully straighten the leg and arm; slow 3-second reps. |

### Workout C - Full Body Burn

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bodyweight Squat | Quads, glutes, core | Lower for 3 seconds, pause 1 second at the bottom, then stand. |
| 2 | Push-Up | Chest, shoulders, triceps, core | 3-second lowering; feet on a low step. |
| 3 | Mountain Climber | Core, shoulders, conditioning | Faster pace; floor-level hands. |
| 4 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Slow 3-second lowering; add a knee-lift at the top. |
| 5 | Plank | Entire core, shoulders | Full plank on toes; lift one foot a few inches. |

### Workout D - Lower + Core

| # | Exercise | Focus | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Reverse Lunge | Quads, glutes, balance | Slow 3-second lowering; add a knee-lift at the top. |
| 2 | Hip Hinge (Good Morning) | Hamstrings, glutes, lower back | Slow 3-second lowering; single-leg hinge with a light toe tap. |
| 3 | Glute Bridge | Glutes, hamstrings | Hold 2 seconds at the top, or lift one foot (single-leg bridge). |
| 4 | Bird Dog | Core, glutes, back | Pause 3 seconds; touch elbow to knee under you between reps. |
| 5 | Mountain Climber | Core, shoulders, conditioning | Faster pace; floor-level hands. |

Phase 4 notes: use the Harder column as your target. Keep each rep controlled.

# Week-by-Week Overview

| Week | Phase | Sessions | Timing | Rounds |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Foundation | 3 | 30 sec work / 30 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 2 | Foundation | 3 | 30 sec work / 30 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 3 | Foundation | 3 | 40 sec work / 20 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 4 | Foundation | 3 | 40 sec work / 20 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 5 | Build | 3 | 40 sec work / 20 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 6 | Build | 3 | 40 sec work / 20 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 7 | Build | 3 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 8 | Build | 3 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 3 rounds |
| 9 | Strengthen | 4 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 10 | Strengthen | 4 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 11 | Strengthen | 4 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 12 | Strengthen | 4 | 45 sec work / 15 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 13 | Transform | 4 | 50 sec work / 10 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 14 | Transform | 4 | 50 sec work / 10 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 15 | Transform | 4 | 50 sec work / 10 sec rest | 4 rounds |
| 16 | Transform | 4 | 50 sec work / 10 sec rest | 4 rounds |

# Progress Tracker

| Week | Date | Weight (lb) | Waist (in) | Sessions done | Energy (1-10) | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | | | | |
| 2 | | | | | | |
| 3 | | | | | | |
| 4 | | | | | | |
| 5 | | | | | | |
| 6 | | | | | | |
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| 11 | | | | | | |
| 12 | | | | | | |
| 13 | | | | | | |
| 14 | | | | | | |
| 15 | | | | | | |
| 16 | | | | | | |

**Test week benchmarks (Week 1 vs Week 16)**

| Test | Week 1 | Week 16 |
|---|---|---|
| Max clean push-ups (incline or floor) | | |
| Bodyweight squats in 60 seconds | | |
| Plank hold (seconds) | | |
| Waist / hips / chest (in) | | |

*This program is general fitness guidance, not medical advice. Consult your physician before beginning any exercise program.*